XCITY · URBAN DESIGN AND AI PLANNING CALLS

DESIGN PRACTICE CALL

Redesigning a city for the silicon age.

San Juan, Argentina · qualifications and initial ideas, then design by a shortlist

Free to apply | Two stages | 1,656 km²

Competition brief



Design Practice Call · Brief

Version: 26 October 2026. Online registration and draft preparation; final submission dates pending. Online application: https://xcity-practice-applications.jingyuan-huang.chatgpt.site The same current brief as a PDF: `brief/design-practice-brief.en.pdf`

XCITY runs two separate calls on one site. This one, the **Design Practice Call**, looks for urban design and planning practices able to propose a city of real spatial quality, and to take it further. The other, the Open Agent Call, tests whether an AI agent can plan on its own; it has its own brief and review. The two share the site and its conditions (`brief/site-conditions.en.md`) and are reviewed and ranked separately.

Organiser	XCITY
Site	San Juan province, Argentina - 1,656 km2 of continuous land east of the Andes
Procedure	Two stages: register and prepare an online application, then submit it for selection; paid design by five shortlisted practices
Fees	None: there is no fee to apply or to take part
Honorarium and prize	US$50,000 to each of the five for a compliant stage-two entry; US$50,000 more to one winner
Languages	Stage 1 in English or Chinese; stage 2 in English
Contact	competition@xcity.ai

1. What XCITY wants from this call

A spatial framework for the whole site, a phase-one city that can run on its own, and representative urban design that a team can carry into further work. Not a single building, a branding exercise or a picture of the future.

Guiding question. When energy, compute, agents and robots become the base of production, how should a new city's structure, uses and public life be designed? A scheme answers three things together: how a city built on solar power and compute stands up on dry, seismic, windy land; how an economy with few jobs supports a city with a full public life; how people, autonomous vehicles and robots share urban space.

2. Procedure

Stage 1 · Registration, draft preparation and final application. Open to every practice that meets section 8, free of charge. Register basic institution and contact details through the online application service. This creates a private draft and management link; no initial ideas or attachments are required at registration. Return through that link to fill in the team and relevant experience, supply applicable evidence and prepare initial ideas of **up to 10 pages**. Save partial drafts and replace attachments before final submission. Submit the complete application when the final submission window opens. Registration, saving a draft and receipt of files do not constitute eligibility approval or shortlisting. The organiser checks eligibility first, then reviews eligible teams, experience and ideas and selects five. Stage one is unpaid. The final timing policy and dates are published with the formal rules; no fixed number of days after registration is assumed.

The initial ideas are asked for because XCITY wants to see each team's own understanding of this site before the five are chosen. They cover only the reading of the site, the design direction and the way of working - not a full masterplan or renderings.

Stage 2 · Design, by the shortlisted teams. Shortlisted teams receive the full site package, an online briefing and a written question period, and design the four layers in section 3. Each of the five that delivers a compliant entry receives US$50,000; one winner receives a further US$50,000.

Review and selection. Shortlisted teams present online to the jury. XCITY may invite the winning team to discuss further work under a separate agreement.

3. Scope: four layers, one plan

Layer	Extent	Decides	Depth
1 · The whole site	All 1,656 km2	Where to protect, produce and build; centres, corridors, capacity and phasing	Districts and networks: real position, size, link and basis
2 · Phase one	Drawn and argued by the team	Where the city starts and how it runs on its own	Layout, services, utilities, first works and expansion
3 · Urban design zoom-in	Chosen by the team inside phase one; no fixed area	How the layout becomes streets, blocks and public space	Blocks, massing, heights, public realm, interfaces, design guidelines
4 · Key issues	Placed in layers 1-3, with their phase	How people and machines actually use the space	Plans, sections, flows and operating scenarios

Not suitable: a scheme that designs one district well and leaves the rest of the site as a colour diagram; key issues that are not placed in the plan above them.

The whole site: ten things to decide

1. Suitability: what is protected, limited and buildable, and why

2. Spatial structure: one city or several settlements, centres and the direction of growth

3. Land-use framework, buffers and reserves

4. Population, jobs and capacity by district

5. Ecology, water and open space

6. Transport, logistics and the human-machine system

7. Water and utilities

8. Energy, compute and communications

9. Public services and centres

10. Phasing, reserves and order of works

Depth: position, size, link and basis; buildings as capacity and form principles. Items may share drawings, but each must be findable. Compare at least two ways to start the city and say why one is chosen. Protection, agriculture and long-term reserves are part of the plan too.

Phase one

Phase one sets out housing, jobs, schools, clinics and shops, production and maintenance, on-site logistics, access, energy, water, wastewater reuse, waste and emergency services, and shows they work without later phases. Later phases are triggered by conditions that can be observed, not by dates.

Reference scenario. Every team works to the same phase-one scenario: **50,000 residents, 20,000 jobs, 200 MW of compute load, 1-3 GW of solar**. The water for it is not secured: state the source you assume. The long-term size is for the scheme to argue.

Urban design zoom-in. Choose an area of the phase-one city to take to urban-design depth. There is no fixed size, but it must be enough to test a centre, typical housing and a production or infrastructure edge.

Key issues: three in depth, eight in principle

Six key issues - **choose three to develop in depth** (site plan, sections, flows, building or space prototype, operation):

- Arrival into the city
- Housing community and prototypes
- A quiet place at the foot of the mountain
- Logistics hub and trade gateway
- Compute campus and its waste heat
- Streets shared with driverless vehicles

Five strategic issues, joined by the three key issues not chosen - **answer these eight in principle** (position in the plan, spatial principles, a typical response):

- Drone landing and docking
- Solar agriculture and the city edge
- Seasonal river parks
- Places for art and culture
- Public space in heat, sun and wind

Each issue is placed in the whole-site plan and phase one, with its phase. Related issues may share a site and drawings.

4. Given conditions

- **The pilot area is not open to design**: agrivoltaic fields 01-03 (13.9 km2; the symbiotic system of jojoba, rosemary, forage cactus and alpaca under the arrays keeps its layout) and the living quarter, phase 1 (2.48 km2, outline only). A scheme meets it; it does not redraw it.

- **Compute is placed as POD clusters**: XCITY's modular data centres, near the solar connection points. Their layout, service roads, waste heat and buffers are for the design.

- The site conditions every design answers - water, earthquakes, the Zonda, dry channels, dark sky, the missing road, phase one standing on its own - are in `brief/site-conditions.en.md`.

5. What to send at stage 1

One online application, comprising form information and applicable attachments. Applicants do not need to merge every item into a single PDF or prepare the ideas before registering.

1. Institution, team and evidence. Fill in the text fields, then upload files or provide the accepted alternative below.

Item	How to provide it	What is checked
Institution and contact	Form: legal name, country/jurisdiction, contact name and email	Who is applying and how to contact them
Legal registration	Registration certificate, business record or official registry link; one verifiable form of evidence is sufficient	The practice's legal identity

Item	How to provide it	What is checked
Professional qualification, where applicable	Applicable licence/permit file, or an explanation of the local registration/licensing system and equivalent evidence	The qualification appropriate to the applicant's jurisdiction and work; no universal certificate title is prescribed
Actual team and roles	Form text identifying lead, key members, disciplines and responsibilities	Who will do the work and how expertise is covered
Relevant projects	Portfolio file or project links; state location, scale, year, status and actual role	Relevant experience and attributable contribution
Consortium, if applicable	Signed consortium agreement or signed statement of members, lead and roles	Who applies together and who leads
Declaration and private review notice	Confirm at final submission	Accuracy, project credits, conflicts and permission to store the application privately for review

Ordinary electronic copies or scans are sufficient for the application; notarisation, certification and paper originals are not requested at this stage. Further verification may be requested before appointment. For file fields use PDF, PNG or JPG as indicated, no more than 10 MB per file and 25 MB across all application files. Files are private to authorised reviewers and are not published with the public repository. Keep the management link: its holder can access and edit the draft. The service does not automatically send an email. Contact competition@xcity.ai if help or a correction after final submission is needed.

2. Initial ideas, up to 10 pages (a slide deck is fine). Only the reading of the site, the design direction and the way of working. Suggested content:

1. The reading of the site and the key questions: which conditions really shape the plan.

2. The whole site and the five systems, as simple diagrams.

3. How phase one starts: a first location or the principles for choosing it, and how it meets the pilot area.

4. One representative spatial idea, as a sketch, diagram or section.

5. Method and team: what you would verify once shortlisted, and who does what, including AI tools if you use them.

Sketches, diagrams and relationship drawings are enough. **No full masterplan or rendering is asked for**, and none earns marks. Ideas that are not shortlisted remain the authors' and are used only for selection; they are not adapted, built or published without the authors' consent.

6. What to submit at stage 2

Boards	Six A0 boards, landscape: the whole site, phase one, the zoom-in and the key issues
Report	A3, up to 60 pages including appendices, with an index from each requirement to its drawing
Design statement	Up to 800 words: concept, response to the site, approach
Preview image	One image for the website and publicity
Data	A metrics workbook (XLSX: units, scope and basis for every figure) and CAD / GIS files
Language and anonymity	English; boards carry no practice name or logo

Video and physical models are optional. More pages or media earn no marks. File formats, size limits, naming and the upload link are published with the formal rules.

Recommended board content: the whole site (the ten decisions); phase one and how it runs on its own; the urban-design zoom-in (blocks, massing, public space); three key issues in depth and eight in principle; the balance of water, energy and compute; phasing, first works and conditions for delivery.

7. Evaluation criteria

Stage 1 · application and initial ideas. Eligibility is checked first; the ideas of ineligible applicants are not read. Eligible applications are then assessed on the initial ideas (does the reading of the site catch what matters; do the whole site, the five systems and phase one hold together), relevant experience (scale, climate, new settlement, energy and water), the quality of the reference work, and the range the team covers. The highest-ranked practices may be invited to an online interview with the lead designer.

Stage 2 · scheme review. Each entry is checked for completeness and compliance, then scored:

Criterion	What the jury looks for
Site reading and spatial structure	Would the plan be different on another site? Do water, slope, wind, earthquakes and the pilot area shape where the city goes and how it grows?
Systems and resources	Do water, energy, compute, population and services support each other, with a shortage scenario that changes the plan?
Urban and spatial quality	Are streets, blocks, centres and public spaces worth living in, in this climate, for different people?

Criterion	What the jury looks for
Phasing and delivery	Can phase one be built and run on its own; are the first works, dependencies and triggers credible?
Interfaces and readiness for further work	Are the interfaces between disciplines clear? Is the scheme ready to be taken further? Are the questions still to be verified named?
Presentation and communication	Are complex ideas clear, and consistent between drawings, figures and text?

The weight of each criterion is published with the formal rules.

8. Who can apply

The call is open to every practice; XCITY may also invite practices to apply. Every applicant follows the same submission requirements and review criteria, and five are chosen for stage two.

- The applicant is a legally registered design practice or a consortium, holding the planning, architecture or landscape licence or business registration that applies where it is registered.

- The team covers masterplanning, urban design, and landscape and ecology, and sets out how water, energy, transport and delivery expertise is brought in.

- A consortium may meet the requirements together; a firm may lead or join one team only.

- No Argentine partner is needed to apply. XCITY arranges local collaboration for the selected team.

- Organiser staff, jury members and their immediate families may not take part.

9. How to apply

There is no application fee.

1. **Read and register.** Download the current brief and stage-one site data. Create an online application with basic institution and contact information. No concept or attachment is needed yet.

2. **Prepare and save.** Keep the private management link. Complete the team and experience fields, upload applicable evidence or links, and add an initial-ideas PDF of up to 10 pages. Save partial drafts and return later.

3. **Submit the final application.** When the formal submission window is open, confirm the declarations and submit the complete application. The receipt confirms storage, not eligibility or shortlisting. The organiser first checks eligibility, then assesses the eligible teams, experience and ideas and selects five for paid design. Timetable and deadlines are published separately; until then the service allows preparation but does not accept final submissions.

Optional “register interest” on the call website only concerns updates; it is separate from creating a formal application draft.

10. Honorarium, jury and terms

- **Stage one** is unpaid. **Honorarium**: US$50,000 to each of the five shortlisted practices that delivers a compliant stage-two entry, whatever its placing. **Prize**: US$50,000 more to one winner. **Further work**: XCITY may invite the winning team to discuss further work under a separate agreement; winning is not itself a commission.

- **Jury**: qualified experts in planning, architecture, landscape and energy infrastructure. Do not contact jury members about the call; doing so may lead to disqualification.

- **Conduct**: work must be original and must not infringe the rights of others. AI tools may be used; disclose how, and the team stays responsible for the result. No claim of official approval, permit or statutory status.

- **Publicity**: shortlisted and selected work may be shown on XCITY's website, in exhibitions and publications; every image, map and AI-generated element must be legally publishable.

11. Published with the formal rules

The dates (application deadline, shortlist, briefing, submission, presentations, results), the jury members, the weight of each criterion, authorship and intellectual property, and the terms of further work are published with the formal rules. From then on the formal rules govern, and changes are logged in `CHANGELOG.md`.

12. Materials

- **Stage 1:** this brief, the online application service and the stage-one site data (`brief/design-practice-stage1-data.zip`: site and pilot-area boundaries as KMZ, DXF and SHP, and analysis maps), all on the call's web page.

- **Stage 2:** the full site package (boundaries, pilot area, terrain, channels, roads, indicative systems), an online briefing and written answers, for the shortlisted teams.

- Not supplied (held by others): official cadastre, grid connection and capacity, water rights, a climate series.